



theWindow

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Prostitutes and Tax Collectors

BY PRESTON GRAHAM



from the Pastor

Several sermons ago, we heard about the church of Ephesus in John's Revelation—a church commended for its orthodoxy and stand against heresy, but a church that had negated its first calling to witness the “good news” of the doctrines of grace to the world. In another recent sermon, we heard about the church of Pergamum, which had the opposite problem—it was commended for its “witness” but rebuked for not preserving orthodoxy. This illustrates how healthy churches will be characterized by impulses to both “guard” and eagerly express the gospel. The historical examples of Ephesus and Pergamum show us how truth and grace are mutually compatible. The life of Christ also provides a good demonstration of this compatibility.

Have you ever noticed the kinds of people who hung around Jesus? Have you ever noticed the response of those who didn't hang around the people who hung around

Jesus? Let's listen in for a moment.

“The Pharisees and their scribes were complaining to his disciples, saying, ‘Why do you eat and drink with tax collectors and sinners?’” —Luke 5:30

Christ's response was nothing short of amazing: “The prostitutes and the tax collectors are entering the kingdom of God before you....” —Matt. 21:31

Consider for a moment how this conversation might sound today. I would imagine an

Grace means that the only way for us to go to heaven is by the miracle of God's grace, and no one is beyond hope!

expanded modern-day version of the response going something like this:

Before who? Before me, my kind... come on! You mean those types will enter the kingdom of God before me and mine who go to church, read books on raising godly children, and practice godly piety? Man, what are you talking about? I've worked hard at keeping myself unstained from this world! I listen to wholesome music, I hear the word preached, and I partake of the Lord's supper

every week. I eat the right foods, I study theology, I... I... I mean, I've worked hard at keeping myself and my family at a proper distance from those types who might be a bad influence on me and mine. I mean really, who do you think you are anyway? If you were a real prophet sent from God, you wouldn't be catering to sinners like that. You wouldn't be telling them what they want to hear. You would not be so “seeker-sensitive.”

Hmm.... Sinners were attracted to Christ, and those who considered themselves—well, pretty together—they weren't and they didn't like the fact that those people were. The crowd who hung around Jesus created a great problem for the moralists. Jesus was often found in awkward situations, to say the least—being alone with a prostitute at the well, being worshipped by a prostitute as she used the very tools of her trade to bathe his feet, eating a lavish meal with a man who was filthy rich, etc. And all the while, he treated these “sinners” with the utmost respect and spoke words of grace to them. And so the questions came—many, many questions! Was Jesus compromising the law of God in order to grow the kingdom of God? Was he saying what sinners wanted him to say in order to attract a following? (see ‘Tax Collectors’ on page 3)

Social Work

by Bennie Kelly



Perspectives

My undergraduate majors in psychology and religious studies were the first steps toward my desired profession—counseling in a Christian context. In college I found that I most like working with children and hoped to find a job that would allow me to invest in the lives of young people. I completed a Master's of Social Work and then came to the Yale Child Study Center as a Social Work Fellow to gain

further clinical experience. While I have not yet pursued an overtly Christian context in which to practice, my faith impacts the way I view my profession and how I practice it.

As a Fellow, I work with a team of people to provide mental health services to kids in the greater New Haven area. Practically, that consists of meeting with about 25 kids a week for individual psychotherapy in an Outpatient Clinic, the New Haven public schools, and Head Start centers. I work with families to assess children's problems and then provide individual and family therapy with the hope of improving their quality of (see ‘Social Work’ on page 2)

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Faith and Science

by Katie Levesque



Our recent Christian Faith and Practice seminar reminded me that science permeates all of our everyday lives, not just those of the scientists among us. Haven't most of us struggled, either personally or with family and

friends, through issues of chemical dependence, mental illness, or infertility? Aren't a lot of us confused and concerned about issues of evolution or genetic engineering? The scientific world has a lot to say about these issues, and they affect us all both emotionally and practically. Above all else, the seminar emphasized that God has revealed himself *both* through Scripture *and* through creation. As such, the scientific study of God's creation is one way that we can glorify and enjoy him, although it cannot replace study of special revelation. We should be thankful that God has given many among us the vocation of studying creation scientifically. As parts of the same body, we all benefit from the skills, gifts, and knowledge of others.

The seminar also emphasized that as Christians we don't need to fear the findings of science—if at times special revelation through Scripture and revelation through the natural world seem to conflict, it is because our understanding is still imperfect on one front or the other. We should expect mystery in this world. Not until we are united with God in heaven will we understand all of the complex mysteries of his glorious creation.

The distinguished panel of scientists that shared their thoughts about how faith affects

their work shed light on a number of current issues, and yet they were honest and humble about not having all the answers. How wonderful it is to trust in Christ alone for our salvation, instead of in the power of our finite minds!

Cliff Bogue discussed the human embryo research, admitting that it has great potential medical benefit but acknowledging the complex moral issues it raises. He feels that embryos should not be created for the purpose of research but finds the issue of already existing frozen embryos more complex. The question he asks as a Christian is, "How can we make decisions that respect the sanctity of life?" Victor Patin explored the issue of mental illness, advocating that scientists work hard to understand the neurobiology involved in mental disorders but urging that we maintain an emphasis on personal responsibility. James Myette discussed questions raised by the Human Genome Project, asserting that the information scientists discover during this research does not belong to us—it is the gift of God and should be used as such. He warned of the danger of distributing value to genes and using them to determine the worth of individual.

Nicole Kho continued that conversation by asking whether human beings are simply collections of genes. Citing her work with development theory, she believes that individuals are much more complex than that, more than a sum total of their parts. Alan Chen and Evan Finch discussed cosmology, the study of the origin of the universe. They marveled at the complexity and wonder of God's creation and explained how large objects in the universe are rushing away from each other, supporting the big bang theory. Above

all, they stressed that theories of physics are consistent with the God's sovereign creation of all things.

Mark Osterlund asserted that the concepts of evolutionary theory are useful in explaining some changes we can observe in nature, like the adaptation of a particular species to new environmental challenges. However, as Christians we must maintain that God created not just human bodies, but human souls—we are made in the *imago Dei*. Any scientific explanation for the mechanisms that God used to create man physically must leave room for God's work of creating the human soul. Mark stressed that evolution is a theory and reminded us that historical questions about the origin of mankind are hard to resolve scientifically because the events cannot be repeated through an experiment. In summation, he concluded that Christians shouldn't be afraid of evolution: if it's wrong, science will discover its error, and if it's right, it must be consistent with faith.

Mark's comments voiced once again the bottom line of the evening: this world is God's, and understanding the creation will help us to understand the Creator. As Christians we can embrace the pursuit of knowledge in the comfort that God is author of all things and the sovereign Lord over all—we cannot discover anything true that is out of accord with his will! May we each pursue our vocations in humble reliance upon God to give us wisdom about how to integrate his common revelation with his special revelation in Scripture.

Katie Levesque is an English teacher at Choate Rosemary Hall.

Social Work (continued from page 1)
life and level of functioning.

As a Christian my job can be frustrating because of the tension between my belief that Christ is my hope and my significance and the tendency in my field toward a more liberal and self-centered approach to healing. Since graduate school and, I expect, for years to come, I have been frequently uncertain about how to integrate these two parts of myself that often seem to conflict. My hope is that as I grow in my understanding of who God is and how God views social problems and internal suffering, I will grow to weed out the falsehoods of social work theories.

As a therapist, I have a unique opportunity to care about children and families

whom I would otherwise never know. I learn much from my clients that relates to my own experience. We are all seeking fulfillment, security, and significance that we will not find in this lifetime. With children, the examples are often very concrete. Recently a parent explained that she could not buy enough to make her son happy. Many depressed children (actually most children) experience these types of feelings, thinking "if I just had the right toy or the right clothes so that other kids would like me, then I could really be happy." My response to this mother is not that her son is greedy, but that he is very sad and is trying to cheer himself up. His sadness is deeper than his desire for possessions. For many parents, on the other hand, their child

is an idol who is supposed to do all the things the parent did not have the opportunity to do. These parents often come to therapy with problems at home when the child is unable to lift the parent's burden of discontented feelings.

I'm often aware of the many common grace elements involved in my work. Children come who have never experienced a stable and kind relationship, and my hope is to build a relationship that will provide a model and a hope for this type of relationship in the child's community or family. For other children I try to provide the chance to learn a new skill, like using words instead of fists to express feelings, or to learn a game that (see 'Social Work' on page 4)

Tax Collectors (continued from page 1)

These questions are answered in the simple introduction to John's gospel. He tells us that Jesus came in truth and grace.

You see, the truth about us all is that we have all fallen short of the glory of God and that only by God's free, unmerited grace are we acceptable in His sight. Jesus didn't confuse outward righteousness with real and inward righteousness. Consequently, he did not see outward sinners as any more sinful than those whose outward righteousness was like "white washed tombs" (his own words). If I think about this for a minute, all sorts of things are turned upside down! If I really understood this truth and grace I could even respect "sinners" since the unbeliever might be a better person than I am even though on the "outside" I am "better" than he or she is! As fellow sinners, we can respect the unbeliever who by God's grace retains something of the imago Dei. The truth is that God came not to save the "righteous" (those who in a comparative manner think of themselves more highly than they ought) but to save sinners (those who are "poor in spirit")! The truth is that all the new moralistic fads, righteousness books, and parenting seminars will not make us one bit more attractive to God so that God would be moved to fellowship with us because of anything

good about us. The truth is that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us! (Rom. 5:8). Grace means that the only way for us to go to heaven is by the miracle of God's grace, and no one is beyond hope! Paul knew grace! Paul in fact knew that he was the "chief of sinners" saved by grace! The truth IS grace and therefore the healthy church will be both preservationist and witness-minded in its approach to ministry.

I wonder, would sinners—the ones aware of their own sin—feel comfortable coming to our church? Do we project the same message of truth and grace that Christ projected so perfectly? Would they know that we know we are sinners saved by grace? Are we willing to get into awkward situations, as Christ did—being alone with a the downcast sinner or eating with the filthy rich sinner? I find it quite curious that the filthy rich and the obscenely poor both felt comfortable hanging out with Jesus. Truly, Christ allowed the touch of the untouchables! Christ loved the unlovely. Christ did not confuse outward or conventional righteousness with the righteousness of God. Christ bestowed peace not to the purist, but to the pardoned! Do we do the same in his name?

What is the message we send to sinners—that we have it together? What barriers have we raised in outward shows of

righteousness to the world? What external codes have we concocted so that we might remain untouchable to the untouchables? Now don't get me wrong: it is perfectly right that we should try to be righteous. But do we send out a message or act as if we really are righteous?

I suspect that living in the world but not of the world is a messy, sometimes confusing business. We will struggle often about when to "abstain" in obedience to Christ and when our abstentions are just our own attempts to seem righteous. But be sure of this: if we are a true church, we will be a church filled with sinners aware of their own sin who are so wrapped in God's grace that we know longer need to project the outward appearances of righteousness in order to be accepted as righteous by God. Have you really experienced that kind of grace? Do you believe that you don't need to project "righteousness" in order to be counted as righteous in Christ? Can you confidently project that which is really in your heart—that you were and remain a sinner and are saved by grace alone?

Reverend Preston Graham is Pastor of Christ Presbyterian Church.

Calvin's *Institutes*

BY TOM MORRISON

Years ago, I remember some college students who chose to read a theological book because it had some interesting illustrations. Perhaps you've had similar tendencies as you've toured the study center library and found yourself consciously avoiding the ominous looking theological tomes that appear to be glaring at you. Surely, The Institutes of the Christian Religion by John Calvin would fit this forbidding category. But fear not, gentle reader, the Institutes are not as menacing as they might first appear. In fact, Calvin's magnum opus, while representing some very confounding theological doctrines, also speaks palatably and sweetly of God's grace to weak sinners.

The weak sinners of Calvin's time were the persecuted French Protestants. Calvin fled Paris and ended up in Basel, Switzerland, where he wrote his first edition of the Institutes. He expedited this first edition in 1536 in order to "defend his slandered fellow

believers." This book, created to catechize (teach) believers, was small enough to fit into the pockets of the persecuted French who were evading those trying to confiscate it.

As the Institutes grew in popularity, it also grew in theological depth and breadth. Many editions and translations were published before the definitive edition appeared in 1559. B. B. Warfield has written, "As the first adequate statement of... the Reformation movement, the Institutes lies at the foundation of the whole development of Protestant theology and has left an impress on evangelical thought which is ineffaceable." In contemporary parlance we could say, "people ate it up!" Additionally, the theology that was imparted to these people provided the soil out of which many of the Protestant churches grew.

Why was this big ol' book so popular and important? Did people during Calvin's time just like to read big books? No, people, as Calvin puts it, were "hungering and thirsting for Christ." In turn, to fulfill this hunger and thirst, people needed to hear about their corruption and the work of Christ that could

liberate them from this state. Theology helped nourish the soul and produce Christian behavior. As John Leith has said, "The true task of theology [for Calvin] was not to give an answer to speculative questions, but to contribute to the edification of Christians. The conduct of the Christian, not verbal assent to doctrine and ceremony, is the decisive test of religious convictions."

True belief that leads to proper Christian conduct is born out of the study of theology. Theology is not reserved for learned scholars but is rather Scriptural truth that speaks life and comfort to the souls of mankind. Calvin was certainly a brilliant scholar, but he nevertheless had the souls of those weary from their sin in view when he wrote the Institutes. Therefore, the next time you're in the library and see Calvin's intimidating book, don't pass it by thinking it is for those who love the obscure—pick it up and savor its goodness as it leads you to the knowledge of God through Christ.

Tom Morrison is Associate Pastor of Christ Presbyterian Church.

Social Work (continued from page 2)
builds the child's confidence that he can succeed in other areas. I also try to set limits for children and help their parents set limits that will keep their children safe.

Finally, I am confronted and comforted every day by the truth that God is sovereign, that he is in control, that he is the healer, and that his plans will not be thwarted. As I work with children who endure horrible con-

ditions of maltreatment, poverty, dangerous neighborhoods, and all sorts of abuse, I find myself in frequent prayer that I'll know how to support families and how and when to intervene, and that I'll develop my trust and faith in Christ and his Providence.

Bennie Kelly is a Clinical Social Work Fellow at the Yale Child Study Center.



Becky Criscuolo, Barbara Battista, Susan Wilhelm, Fran Onofrio and Meg Bogue enjoy a meal together at the Cedarcrest Picnic.

CPC Calendar

February

- 4-6 Family Ski Trip
- 6 Student Link Dinner
- 11-12 Marriage Enrichment
- 13 Missions Banquet
- 13&20 New Members Class (6:30, SC)
- 26 Men's Prayer Breakfast
- 29 "Beat the Blues" Brunch (11-2)

March

- 10-12 Junior High Retreat
- 10 Study Center concert
- 25 Men's Prayer Breakfast
- 31 Servant Leaders' surveys and budgets due



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